ENTHUSIASM

The Missing Energy of a Successful Civilization

Why a world that can do almost anything is struggling to want anything

A book about possibility, agency, civilization, and the future of human commitment

A Note on the Argument

This book advances an interpretive thesis, not a claim that a single measurable quantity called enthusiasm has been proven to decline across all societies. Where empirical research is available, it is used to test mechanisms adjacent to the thesis: autonomy, competence, relatedness, social connection, meaningful work, burnout, collective emotion, and wellbeing.

Historical and contemporary examples are used to illuminate mechanisms rather than to romanticize earlier eras. The argument is explicitly anti-nostalgic: the challenge is to preserve the safety, pluralism, skepticism, and individual freedom of mature societies while recovering room for strong voluntary commitments.

The policy implications are therefore architectural rather than ideological. The aim is not to prescribe one political or economic system, but to identify design properties that make initiative more or less likely: visible consequence, reversible experimentation, credible autonomy, social belonging, skill, trust, and the right to exit.

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The Resource We Forgot to Name

A civilization may possess extraordinary power and still lack compelling reasons to use it.

There are ages that suffer because they cannot do enough, and ages that suffer because they no longer know what is worth doing.

The modern world belongs increasingly to the second category. We have inherited powers that would have looked magical to almost every previous civilization. A person with a modest device can speak across continents, consult libraries that once required a lifetime to assemble, learn almost any technical skill, publish to a global audience, summon machines to perform physical and cognitive work, and now ask artificial intelligence to draft, translate, code, design, search, and reason. Medicine has pushed back diseases that once killed casually. Engineering has made ordinary life safer. Institutions have learned to prevent many kinds of arbitrariness. The range of possible lives has widened.

Yet possibility is not the same thing as desire. Capability is not direction. A civilization can become extraordinarily good at answering the question “How?” while becoming strangely embarrassed by the question “Why?”

This book begins from a suspicion: one of the scarcest resources in successful societies is not information, capital, intelligence, or even attention. It is enthusiasm: the willingness to invest oneself in a possibility before its value has been fully proved. Not cheerfulness, not corporate engagement, not the

compulsory smile of customer service, not the manic insistence that everything is exciting. Enthusiasm is the moment when a future becomes emotionally real enough that effort stops feeling like mere expenditure.

The suspicion should not be exaggerated into a historical claim that cannot be demonstrated. We do not possess a reliable global time series called “human enthusiasm.” People in the past were not permanently animated, and modern people are not uniformly apathetic. Stadiums fill. Scientific communities organize around difficult problems. Fans create extraordinary archives. Open-source projects attract unpaid contributors. Political and religious movements still mobilize intense commitment. New companies are founded every day. Children still become obsessed with dinosaurs, planets, games, music, animals, machines, or stories.

But adjacent indicators justify asking the question. Gallup reported in 2026 that global employee engagement had fallen for a second consecutive year and reached its lowest level since 2020. The World Happiness Report documented substantial declines in youth wellbeing in North America and Western Europe, while also warning that the causes differ across regions and cannot be reduced to one villain such as social media. Its 2025 analysis of young adults found that 19 percent reported having nobody they could count on for social support, a 39 percent increase from 2006. These measurements are not enthusiasm. They are clues about the social soil in which enthusiasm either grows or fails to grow.

The deeper argument of this book is that modernity may contain an enthusiasm paradox. The institutions that made life safer, more predictable, more scalable, and more accountable also tend to lengthen the distance between action and consequence. The expansion of choice can make commitment feel arbitrary. Professionalization can convert callings into careers. Measurement can turn intrinsic projects into performance

indicators. Digital systems can supply endless stimulation while destroying the continuity of attention required for devotion. Success can reduce desperation without automatically producing a positive answer to what freedom is for.

This is not an argument against modernity. Nostalgia is a poor theory of civilization. Earlier worlds supplied abundant enthusiasm partly through war, religion, nationalism, deprivation, rigid identities, and existential danger. Those sources could be magnificent, but they could also be cruel. The goal is not to recover a lost age of conviction by recovering its violence and constraints. The challenge is more difficult: can a civilization preserve skepticism, safety, pluralism, and individual freedom while becoming capable of wholehearted projects again?

That question matters more in the age of artificial intelligence. If machines progressively lower the cost of execution, the premium shifts from doing to choosing. When many things become technically possible, the bottleneck is increasingly the human decision that something deserves to exist. AI can write ten proposals before we have decided whether any proposal is worth pursuing. It can generate images faster than we can learn to see. It can remove drudgery, but it can also remove the friction through which competence, ownership, identity, and attachment are formed. A world of cheap execution could become a renaissance of human initiative or an ocean of perfectly adequate things nobody cares about.

The central claim is therefore modest but demanding: enthusiasm is not a decorative emotion. It is part of the conversion mechanism between possibility and sustained action. It deserves to be understood as seriously as incentives, productivity, risk, and capital. We should know what conditions make it possible, what corrupts it, why modern institutions often sterilize it, and how to build environments in which it can arise without being commanded.

The argument will move from diagnosis to mechanism to design. First, we will examine the success trap: why abundance, complexity, safety, and sophistication can compress dreams rather than enlarge them. Then we will define enthusiasm more carefully, separating it from hope, happiness, passion, flow, hype, and fanaticism. We will look at the social nature of enthusiasm and at its dangerous shadow. Finally, we will ask what workplaces, schools, research institutions, communities, and AI systems would look like if they treated enthusiasm not as a mood to manufacture but as a form of agency to protect.

The ambition is not to make everyone excited all the time. Permanent enthusiasm would be pathological. Grief, boredom, doubt, fatigue, irony, and refusal are necessary human states. The aim is simpler: a good society should contain enough credible possibilities that people periodically encounter something to which they can say, without embarrassment, “I want to give part of my life to this.”

PART I

THE ENTHUSIASM DEFICIT

The problem is not that modern life contains too little stimulation. It is that stimulation and commitment have become increasingly easy to confuse.

CHAPTER 1

The Missing Voltage

A great deal of contemporary life works without requiring anybody to believe in it very much.

Electricity arrives. Payments clear. Warehouses replenish shelves. Bureaucracies process forms. Software deploys. Meetings populate calendars. Schools issue credentials. Corporations report quarterly figures. States administer complicated systems. Much of this is an achievement. A civilization that depends on continuous inspiration would be unstable. Reliability is precisely the capacity to function when nobody wakes up inspired.

The problem begins when reliability expands from a foundation into a complete model of human life. Then the ideal person becomes a dependable component: qualified, measurable, compliant with process, emotionally self-managed, able to deliver against objectives. The system can accommodate intelligence and even creativity, but it prefers them translated into predictable outputs. What does not fit a metric, a role, a quarter, a grant call, a syllabus, or a risk framework acquires the faint odor of irresponsibility.

Enthusiasm is troublesome in such systems because it is excessive by definition. It makes people read after the assignment is complete, build a prototype nobody requested, remain in a laboratory because the result is strange, organize a club, write an obscure book, restore an abandoned place, learn an instrument badly for years, or spend a weekend solving a problem that has no budget code. The immediate output may be worthless. Often it is. But this apparently irrational surplus is where many new directions begin.

We have good theories of incentives and weak theories of voluntary surplus. Economics knows how prices alter behavior.

Management knows how to allocate tasks. Psychology knows a great deal about motivation. Yet institutions repeatedly behave as if the extra energy of people can be purchased in the same way as their time. It cannot. Payment can purchase competent effort, and in decent societies it should. It can even enable enthusiasm by removing fear. But the moment an institution assumes that compensation entitles it to devotion, the relationship becomes morally and psychologically confused.

This distinction matters because the contemporary workplace often tries to erase it. Organizations speak the vocabulary of passion, purpose, belonging, and mission while retaining the employment relationship of exchange. Employees are told to bring their “whole selves” and then evaluated by a dashboard. Leaders ask for entrepreneurial energy but preserve centralized approval. Companies celebrate failure rhetorically while punishing it in promotion decisions. What appears to be an enthusiasm problem is frequently an institutional credibility problem.

The decline in workplace engagement reported by Gallup in 2026 should therefore not be interpreted as proof that people have become lazy or spiritually depleted. Engagement is a specific construct, and employment is only one domain of life. Still, the result is suggestive: even highly optimized organizations can struggle to elicit felt connection. The more interesting question is not why workers fail to become enthusiastic on command. It is why managers expect command to produce enthusiasm at all.

Outside work, a different paradox appears. We live amid unprecedented quantities of expressive material. There is always a new series, controversy, creator, game, product launch, scandal, explanation, subculture, or technological breakthrough. The emotional surface of society is loud. Yet intensity is not depth. A feed can produce a hundred impulses in an hour while leaving no object worthy of a month.

This suggests a useful distinction between stimulation and voltage. Stimulation is the frequency with which something perturbs us. Voltage is the potential difference capable of moving energy through a circuit. Modern environments are rich in perturbation and often poor in sustained potential. They make us react without giving us a direction in which reaction can accumulate.

Enthusiasm requires accumulation. It is built when attention returns to the same object and finds it larger rather than exhausted. A mathematical problem opens another layer. A community develops memory. A craft reveals finer distinctions. A scientific question becomes more interesting as ignorance becomes more precise. A relationship gains history. A place becomes one's responsibility. These are not infinitely novel objects; they are deep objects.

The missing voltage is therefore not simply "motivation." A person can be motivated by fear, debt, status, competition, or necessity and still feel no enthusiasm. The more precise absence is the felt difference between the current world and a possible world that one can help bring into existence. When that difference is credible and personally meaningful, effort has somewhere to flow.

Civilizations need this voltage because maintenance alone cannot choose a future. Systems can preserve themselves for long periods while becoming intellectually and culturally defensive. They learn to ask how to avoid errors, how to comply, how to keep existing institutions solvent, how to protect reputations. These are necessary questions. But a civilization governed only by them slowly becomes an insurance policy against life.

The first task, then, is not to demand more excitement. It is to understand why the distance between possibility and commitment has become difficult to sustain.

CHAPTER 2

The Success Trap

> *The most provocative version of the argument is that advanced societies may suffer partly because they succeeded.*

This needs care. Poverty, disease, arbitrary violence, illiteracy, infant mortality, and political domination are not spiritually useful hardships that should be romanticized. A starving person does not need a lecture about the motivational benefits of scarcity. Security and abundance are achievements. The paradox lies elsewhere: solving problems created by necessity does not automatically tell people what to do with the freedom that follows.

For most of history, large portions of human effort were assigned before reflection. Food had to be produced. Families had to be sustained. Buildings had to survive winter. Communities had to defend themselves. Social roles were narrow, frequently unjust, and difficult to escape. Necessity supplied direction even when it denied autonomy.

Modern success weakens some of those compulsory scripts. Education expands options. Wealth permits delay. Technology reduces the amount of labor required for many tasks. Mobility loosens inherited communities. Contraception separates sexuality from reproduction. Digital work separates income from place. Artificial intelligence may separate production from expertise in still more domains. Each liberation is real. But removing an imposed purpose creates a vacancy. Freedom does not arrive with instructions.

This produces the success trap: the better a civilization becomes at reducing involuntary constraints, the more it must learn to generate voluntary commitments. It must become good

not only at freeing people from bad options but at making good options intelligible, accessible, and worth choosing.

That second capacity is much less developed. We teach people how to preserve optionality for a long time. High performers learn to keep doors open: obtain credentials, avoid irreversible mistakes, build transferable skills, maintain a network, save money, cultivate a personal brand. All of this is rational under uncertainty. But a life optimized indefinitely for optionality can become a life in which nothing is selected strongly enough to reorganize the self.

Enthusiasm is intrinsically anti-option. To become enthusiastic about something is to allow one possibility to become temporarily more important than its alternatives. This does not require permanent commitment. It requires asymmetry. A project begins to win.

Contemporary culture often makes such asymmetry feel intellectually suspect. Every enthusiasm can be deconstructed. The startup may fail. The political movement may become corrupt. The research program may be fashionable nonsense. The institution may exploit you. The relationship may end. The artistic career may never pay. The community may disappoint. These warnings are not imaginary; history justifies them. Cynicism often begins as intelligence.

But skepticism has an asymmetrical advantage: it can invalidate without constructing. The person who proposes a future assumes the burden of detail. The critic needs only one contradiction. In complex societies, sophisticated people learn quickly that enthusiasm exposes them. To care visibly is to risk appearing naïve. Irony becomes armor. Detachment signals that one has not been captured.

The result can be a peculiar status hierarchy in which the person who explains why a proposal will fail appears more mature than the person willing to attempt it. This is healthy when

enthusiasm is reckless. It is destructive when the cost of embarrassment exceeds the cost of stagnation.

Success also increases the complexity of intervention. A person who wants to build a bridge, develop a medicine, open a school, restore a neighborhood, launch a financial product, run an experiment, or change a public system encounters a thick environment of law, safety, standards, finance, professional expertise, insurance, procurement, environmental constraints, data governance, and reputational risk. Most of these layers emerged for reasons. Bridges should not collapse. Medicines should not poison people. Schools should protect children. Financial products should not quietly transfer risk to the uninformed.

But every legitimate layer increases the distance between impulse and consequence. In a small workshop, an idea can become an object by evening. In a mature system, an idea may first become a proposal, then a review, a budget, an assessment, a committee decision, a compliance package, a procurement process, a pilot, and eventually an object whose original author barely recognizes it. The system becomes safer while the causal experience of agency becomes weaker.

Enthusiasm feeds on visible causality: I did this, and something changed. When causal chains lengthen, the emotional return on initiative is delayed and distributed. People can remain professionally productive while losing the sense that their actions enter the world.

This is why the solution cannot be a general revolt against institutions. The real design problem is to preserve the protections of maturity while recovering pockets of immediacy. A successful civilization needs safe zones for unsafe ideas, reversible spaces in which action has visible consequences, and cultural permission for commitments that are not fully optimized in advance.

The success trap is not that comfort makes people weak. It is that mature societies become extraordinarily competent at preventing certain kinds of failure and insufficiently competent at making meaningful attempts easy enough to begin.

CHAPTER 3

Dream Compression

A child can want to become an astronomer because Saturn has rings. An adult is expected to know the funding landscape.

Between those two states lies a normal process of maturation. Dreams acquire constraints. Talent is tested. Costs appear. Vague identities become concrete practices. There is nothing noble about refusing reality. Yet modern institutions often force this compression too early. A possibility must justify itself before it has had time to become emotionally and intellectually rich.

Call this dream compression: the translation of a broad, living aspiration into a sequence of administratively legible milestones until the aspiration is either reduced to a career path or discarded as unrealistic.

Education performs much of this translation. A student's interest in living systems becomes grades, admissions, prerequisites, internships, publications, and a labor market. A fascination with machines becomes a degree plan. A desire to write becomes portfolio strategy and platform building. A concern for justice becomes a credentialed field. These paths can enable mastery; they are not the enemy. The danger is that the route becomes so salient that the original object disappears. One learns how to become a researcher more clearly than why a question was worth researching.

Professionalization intensifies the effect. Mature fields develop standards because standards protect quality. But standards also teach entrants what counts. Research questions become grant-shaped. Art becomes festival-shaped. Entrepreneurship becomes investor-shaped. Public service becomes procedure-shaped. The

novice learns the grammar of legitimacy before developing a private reason to speak.

This is one reason contemporary people can appear strangely exhausted by opportunities. The opportunity arrives bundled with an implied optimization problem. Should I turn this hobby into content? Should this project become a startup? Should I build an audience? Should I monetize the newsletter? Should I obtain a credential? Should I quantify progress? The act is pulled immediately into an external economy of evaluation.

Enthusiasm needs a protected pre-economic phase. Before a project is useful, profitable, publishable, scalable, or prestigious, it may need to be merely absorbing. This is not childishness. It is incubation. Many forms of value are illegible before they become developed enough to be judged.

The same is true socially. A small group can become enthusiastic when it is allowed to develop its own language, rituals, jokes, standards, and problems. But contemporary networks expose projects early to large audiences. Early exposure introduces comparison. A half-formed idea is placed beside the finished work of thousands of others. The result is often not inspiration but premature self-evaluation.

Algorithmic environments deepen the compression by making visible how many alternatives exist. The musician does not compare herself with five local musicians but with an archive of the world. The young researcher sees the publication records of prodigies. The founder sees companies that reached a billion-dollar valuation in less time than it took to build a prototype. Scale changes the reference class.

Under these conditions, modest enthusiasm feels embarrassing. Why care about repairing a small park when others claim to be saving the planet? Why write a careful book for a thousand readers when creators chase millions? Why build a useful tool for one scientific community when the dominant language is platforms and markets? The comparison does not

need to be explicit. The infrastructure of visibility performs it continuously.

A healthier culture would distinguish magnitude from intensity. Some of the best human commitments are small in scope and large in meaning. A neighborhood archive, a specialized open-source library, a local orchestra, a difficult theorem, a rare-language dictionary, a long friendship, an amateur observatory, a meticulous restoration project: none needs planetary scale to justify devotion.

This gives us the first nontrivial design principle of enthusiasm: preserve a zone in which a project can become itself before it must explain itself to the world.

Organizations can do this by providing small discretionary budgets without demanding business cases for every experiment. Schools can do it by allowing projects whose evaluation is delayed until completion. Research institutions can fund exploratory time in which the question, not only the answer, is still allowed to change. Individuals can do it by refusing to publish every beginning.

The point is not secrecy. It is temporal protection. A seed is not improved by being audited every morning.

Dream compression also happens through language. Adults learn to describe aspirations in defensive terms: “a side project,” “just an experiment,” “probably nothing,” “I’m playing with an idea.” Sometimes this is prudent. Often it is a ritual apology for caring. The apology protects status if the project fails.

Enthusiasm requires a limited suspension of that protection. Not grandiosity, not certainty—simply the willingness to let a possibility occupy more psychological space than its current evidence strictly warrants. Every serious project contains such an interval. Before it earns credibility, someone has to lend it credibility from their own future.

The problem with a culture of permanent evaluation is that it consumes this loan too quickly.

CHAPTER 4

Attention Without Direction

It is tempting to blame the decline of deep enthusiasm on digital technology. The temptation should be resisted long enough to become precise.

The 2026 World Happiness Report offers a useful warning against monocausal stories. Youth wellbeing has fallen sharply in North America and Western Europe, but not in the same way across most of the world, despite widespread social-media use. Heavy use is associated with lower wellbeing in several settings, especially with passive, visually comparative, algorithmically curated platforms, yet communication and content creation can be associated with better outcomes. The medium matters, the use matters, and the surrounding society matters.

For enthusiasm, the key issue is not screen time as such. It is the architecture of temporal experience.

Enthusiasm needs recurrence. One returns to the same question, person, craft, place, or project. The object accumulates associations. Skill makes new details visible. Difficulty becomes informative. Progress becomes legible. Identity begins to reorganize around the commitment. This requires stretches of time in which competing objects are absent enough for one object to become deep.

Feeds are designed around a different logic: renewal by replacement. The next item must earn attention before the previous one has fully settled. Novelty becomes a continuous service. Even when individual items are intelligent, beautiful, or moving, the sequence trains a particular relationship to interest: when friction appears, another object is available.

The psychological danger is not simply distraction. It is the conversion of curiosity from a path into a surface. One becomes

highly informed about beginnings and poorly practiced at continuations.

This helps explain why contemporary life can feel simultaneously overstimulating and under-animated. We encounter countless sparks, but few fires. A person may spend an evening consuming stories of scientific breakthroughs, artists, entrepreneurs, travelers, athletes, and political struggles and go to sleep with less desire to act than before. The feed has supplied the emotional preview of agency without requiring agency itself.

There is a structural asymmetry here. Consumption offers immediate affect at low cost. Creation offers delayed affect at uncertain cost. A rational nervous system under fatigue often chooses the cheaper reward. The problem is not moral weakness. The environment prices the alternatives differently.

Artificial intelligence may intensify this problem if it makes not only consumption but pseudo-creation immediate. A user can request a song, essay, image, application, business plan, or game and receive a plausible artifact before developing the skill or obsession that would once have grown around making it. This is extraordinary capability. It can democratize expression. It can also sever ownership from formation.

The relevant distinction is between reducing unnecessary friction and abolishing formative friction. Unnecessary friction is the clerical work that does not deepen understanding: formatting references, converting file types, searching repetitive documentation, reconciling boilerplate, cleaning data in predictable ways. Formative friction is the encounter with resistance through which the person learns what the activity is: revising an argument until its weakness becomes visible, debugging enough to develop a mental model, practicing a passage until one hears the difference, wrestling with a proof until the definitions stop being decorative.

Enthusiasm often survives difficulty because difficulty reveals depth. If every difficulty is interpreted as a UX defect, the world becomes smooth and strangely shallow.

This does not mean that suffering is necessary for meaning. It means that agency requires consequences and competence requires resistance. A world optimized only for ease may unintentionally remove the evidence that one is becoming capable.

The alternative to attention extraction is therefore not merely “digital wellbeing.” It is directional attention: environments that help people return. A good tool remembers the long project, not only the latest prompt. A good community gives unfinished work a place to reappear. A good education system creates sequences in which yesterday’s difficulty becomes today’s skill. A good personal practice makes continuation easier than substitution.

Enthusiasm is not protected by reducing the number of interesting things in the world. It is protected by allowing some interesting things to become important.

PART II

WHAT ENTHUSIASM IS

Enthusiasm is not a synonym for positive emotion. It is a specific relationship between a person and a possible future.

CHAPTER 5

The Emotion of Possibility

The word itself arrives carrying a warning. The Greek enthousiasmos referred to being filled or possessed by a god. The earliest image is not of a productive employee but of a person seized by something larger than ordinary calculation.

Modern secular culture is uncomfortable with possession, and rightly so. Yet the old word preserved an important phenomenological fact: genuine enthusiasm feels partly as if the source of energy is outside the ordinary self. The person does not merely decide, in a cold sequence, to allocate additional effort. The project begins to pull.

Psychology does not offer a single canonical theory of enthusiasm. It appears within broader measures of positive affect and high activation, near states such as excitement, inspiration, interest, and vitality. That scientific ambiguity is useful because the everyday phenomenon cuts across several established categories.

Enthusiasm contains positive affect, but it is not happiness. One can be frightened, exhausted, grieving, or angry and remain enthusiastic about something. A scientist can be discouraged by repeated failure and still be unable to abandon a question. A political dissident can live under terrible conditions and retain extraordinary commitment. An artist can hate the current draft and love the work.

Enthusiasm resembles hope, but hope can remain passive. One may hope that a disease is cured by someone else. Enthusiasm tends to recruit the self: perhaps I can contribute.

It resembles curiosity, but curiosity is satisfied by finding out. Enthusiasm often deepens after finding out because knowledge creates a larger field of action.

It resembles passion, but passion can be possessive and narrow. Psychological research on passion distinguishes harmonious forms, integrated with the rest of life, from obsessive forms that control the person. Enthusiasm can move in either direction, but the form worth cultivating retains the capacity to stop, revise, and share.

It resembles flow, but flow is a state of deep absorption in an activity. Enthusiasm can exist before the skill required for flow and after the flow state ends. A novice may be enthusiastic precisely because competence is still distant.

It resembles purpose, but purpose is a structure of direction at the scale of a life or long period. Enthusiasm is more episodic and energetic. Purpose without enthusiasm can become duty; enthusiasm without purpose can become a succession of brilliant starts.

A useful working definition is this: enthusiasm is a high-energy, voluntary orientation toward a possibility experienced as both meaningful and actionable.

Every term matters. High-energy distinguishes it from calm approval. Voluntary distinguishes it from coerced effort. Possibility makes it future-facing. Meaningful distinguishes it from pure stimulation. Actionable distinguishes it from admiration at a distance.

This definition also explains why enthusiasm is fragile. Remove voluntariness and it becomes compliance. Remove meaningfulness and it becomes excitement. Remove actionability and it becomes fantasy. Remove the future and it becomes satisfaction with what already exists. Remove energy and it becomes preference.

The most important element may be possibility. Enthusiasm is an emotion of the not-yet. It arises when the future appears open enough to matter but closed enough to enter. If success is guaranteed, the state becomes anticipation. If success is impossible, it becomes longing. Enthusiasm occupies the middle region in which agency might make a difference.

This middle region can be called the near frontier. A frontier is not necessarily geographic or technological. It is any boundary between what one can already do and what one can plausibly learn, build, understand, repair, discover, or organize next. The near frontier is close enough to touch and distant enough to expand the self.

Children find near frontiers everywhere because almost everything is new and because adults often structure progression for them. A puzzle has one more difficulty. A game unlocks another level. A musical instrument reveals the next piece. A book opens another world. Adult institutions are often worse at making frontiers visible. Work is decomposed into tasks; expertise becomes maintenance; large systems hide consequences. People can become more capable while encountering fewer moments in which capability feels newly consequential.

This suggests why enthusiasm should not be treated as an internal personality trait. Some people are dispositionally more energetic and expressive, but environments strongly alter what is possible to care about. Self-Determination Theory is especially relevant here. Decades of research organized around autonomy, competence, and relatedness show that high-quality motivation depends on social conditions, not merely character. People become more active when they experience volition, effectiveness, and connection.

Enthusiasm may be understood as one of the experiential forms that appear when those conditions converge around a compelling possibility. Autonomy says: this is mine to choose.

Competence says: I may be able to move it. Relatedness says: I am not alone, or what I do matters to someone. The possibility supplies direction.

What enthusiasm adds is emotional acceleration. It is the moment these components stop being abstract goods and become attached to something specific enough to act upon.

The opposite of enthusiasm is therefore not sadness. Sad people can be enthusiastic. The deeper opposite is felt futility: the conviction that no available action connects the self to a future worth entering.

CHAPTER 6

Ignition

Why does one project suddenly come alive while another equally worthy project remains inert?

There is no universal formula. Human beings differ, histories differ, and the same object can be electrifying in one period of life and irrelevant in another. Still, several recurrent conditions help explain ignition.

The first is authorship. People can work intensely on goals they did not invent, but enthusiasm is easier when they experience some part of the goal as self-endorsed. This is the practical force behind autonomy in Self-Determination Theory. Autonomy does not mean isolation or total freedom from constraint. A musician can enthusiastically interpret a score written centuries ago. A scientist can become absorbed in a question proposed by a supervisor. A volunteer can enter an existing organization. What matters is that participation becomes psychologically one's own rather than merely imposed.

The second is effective difficulty. A task that is too easy generates no frontier; one that is too difficult produces helplessness. Enthusiasm likes the zone where effort changes probability. This is related to competence but more dynamic: I do not need to be good yet, but I need evidence that becoming better would matter.

The third is visible consequence. Modern systems frequently destroy this link. A worker adjusts a spreadsheet that changes a forecast that influences a budget that eventually alters a product. The contribution may be real but emotionally opaque. By contrast, a programmer sees a bug disappear, a teacher sees a student understand, a gardener sees a damaged space recover, a researcher watches an unexpected signal appear. The tighter the

feedback between effort and world, the easier it is for effort to acquire meaning.

The fourth is social resonance. Enthusiasm becomes more credible when another person recognizes the object. This need not be praise. In fact, indiscriminate praise often cheapens a project. What matters is the experience that someone else can see why the question is interesting. A single serious collaborator can sustain a project that would die before an indifferent crowd.

The fifth is narrative room. A project needs a story large enough to contain setbacks. If the only story is “this must work,” failure kills enthusiasm. If the story is “we are trying to understand what is possible,” failure can produce information. Good scientific cultures know this. Good exploratory engineering cultures know it. The meaning of a failed attempt depends on the narrative in which it occurs.

The sixth is protected uncertainty. Enthusiasm requires not knowing. If every step, outcome, and evaluation criterion is specified, the person can execute but has little to discover. Conversely, uncertainty without support becomes anxiety. Productive environments define a stable frame and leave meaningful variables open.

This combination explains why small projects can be disproportionately energizing. They often restore authorship, consequence, social visibility, and uncertainty at once. A large organization may offer greater resources but dilute causality. A small team may lack resources but allow a person to see an idea travel from conversation to artifact in days.

The temptation is to convert these observations into a checklist. That would repeat the mistake of the systems we are criticizing. Enthusiasm cannot be engineered in the strong sense. A manager cannot install autonomy on Tuesday and expect inspiration on Thursday. These are enabling conditions, not buttons.

A better metaphor is ignition in combustion. Fuel can be present without burning. Oxygen can be present without burning. Heat can be present without burning. The configuration matters, and once the process begins it changes the conditions that sustain it. Enthusiastic people often become more competent, build stronger relationships, create progress, and discover additional meaning. The state is self-reinforcing for a time.

This is why enthusiasm sometimes appears disproportionate to the original opportunity. A modest experiment becomes a company. A reading group becomes an intellectual movement. A repair project becomes a local institution. A hobby becomes a scientific career. The initial object was not secretly enormous; participation made it larger.

The mechanism also works in reverse. Excessive approval can remove authorship. Excessive evaluation can replace curiosity with self-monitoring. Excessive stakes can turn a near frontier into a threat. Excessive scale can make consequences invisible. Excessive optimization can eliminate the exploratory margin.

The practical question is therefore not “How do we motivate people?” but “What are we doing that makes self-generated energy irrational?”

That question is harder for institutions because the answer may implicate the institution itself.

CHAPTER 7

Enthusiasm Is Social

The solitary genius is one of modern culture's most durable myths. Even when work is performed alone, enthusiasm is usually social in origin, maintenance, or destination.

A writer imagines readers. A mathematician inherits problems from a community. A programmer uses languages built by others. A collector enters a lineage of taste. A child's obsession is amplified by an adult who takes it seriously. The private project lives inside a field of recognition.

Sociology has long had a concept for the more intense version of this phenomenon. Émile Durkheim used "collective effervescence" to describe the emotional energy produced by ritual gatherings in which people experience themselves as part of something larger. Modern research has operationalized related experiences in demonstrations, ceremonies, pilgrimages, festivals, and other gatherings. A 2022 meta-analytic review found associations between collective effervescence and belonging, shared values, efficacy, wellbeing, and a sense of vital energy.

The lesson is easy to trivialize into "people like groups." The more interesting point is that groups can alter the perceived scale of agency. Alone, a person encounters a difficult world. In coordinated action, the same person experiences capabilities that do not exist at the individual level. The future becomes larger because the acting subject becomes larger.

This is one reason enthusiasm spreads. We often describe emotional contagion as imitation, but shared enthusiasm is more than copying someone's expression. Another person's commitment is evidence. It says the object has enough depth to

sustain attention, enough possibility to justify effort, enough social reality to be inhabited by more than one mind.

Good communities therefore do not merely provide encouragement. They provide continuity. When my enthusiasm weakens, yours keeps the object alive. When your skill is insufficient, mine changes what the group can attempt. When one member leaves, memory remains. The project becomes less dependent on a single nervous system.

This helps explain the extraordinary energy of volunteer communities at their best: open-source software, citizen science, fan archives, amateur astronomy, local history, mutual aid, religious communities, artistic scenes, sporting clubs. Their members often perform work that would be expensive to purchase and difficult to command. The economic mistake is to conclude that such labor is free. It is financed in another currency: identity, mastery, belonging, reputation, reciprocal help, access, and the pleasure of contributing to something real.

Exploitative institutions misunderstand this and try to capture the output while externalizing the social costs. They call contributors a “community” but centralize decisions. They encourage unpaid creation while privatizing the resulting value. They invoke mission to justify poor conditions. For a time this can work because enthusiasm is generous. Eventually generosity learns.

A healthy community needs permeability. Members must be able to leave without becoming enemies. New members need paths from observer to participant. Disagreement must not threaten total belonging. The object of enthusiasm should be separable from the moral worth of the person. Otherwise a project becomes an identity trap.

This is where the idea of tribes becomes both attractive and dangerous. Human beings clearly benefit from small groups with shared practices and thick recognition. Modern anonymity often deprives people of precisely that. Yet tribes become destructive

when every dimension of identity is bundled together: if sharing my scientific project requires sharing my politics, aesthetics, social circle, enemies, and moral vocabulary, belonging becomes totalizing.

The better model is incomplete tribes: communities organized around a real object but intentionally incomplete as identities. A laboratory can be a tribe around a question. An orchestra can be a tribe around a repertoire. A local group can be a tribe around a river, a neighborhood, or a school. A technical community can be a tribe around a protocol. Members can care intensely without surrendering the rest of themselves.

Incomplete tribes are especially important for pluralistic societies because they let people experience strong belonging across partial overlaps. Two people may share a research community but not a religion; a sport but not a profession; a city project but not an ideology. Social cohesion then emerges not from total agreement but from intersecting commitments.

Enthusiasm thrives in such structures because it can become collective without becoming absolute.

Modern societies have many audiences and fewer hosts. An audience watches. A host creates conditions under which participants can affect the event. This difference should become central to our understanding of community. The internet made it easy to accumulate spectators; the next challenge is to make participation consequential again.

The healthiest form of contagious enthusiasm is not “Look how excited we are.” It is “There is room for you to change what happens next.”

CHAPTER 8

The Necessary Shadow

Any book that praises enthusiasm without examining its failures would be intellectually irresponsible.

Enthusiasm has powered scientific discovery and artistic creation. It has also powered cults, speculative bubbles, purges, wars, abusive companies, conspiracy movements, and ideological projects that treated doubt as betrayal. Energy is not evidence. Commitment is not virtue. Collective intensity can make false beliefs feel more true precisely because they are shared.

The ancient association between enthusiasm and possession was therefore double-edged from the beginning. To be seized by something can feel transcendent; it can also mean losing the capacity to revise.

The first corruption is hype. Hype borrows the emotional appearance of enthusiasm while reversing its relationship to reality. Authentic enthusiasm tends to deepen through contact with the object. Hype survives by controlling contact. The product is always about to transform everything. The movement is always on the edge of victory. The next funding round, election, launch, revelation, or technological breakthrough will validate belief. Contradictory evidence is treated as a messaging problem.

The second corruption is identity fusion. A project becomes inseparable from self-worth. Criticism of the project becomes criticism of the person. Exit becomes humiliation. This is common in intense startups, activist movements, religious groups, and intellectual schools. The more sacrifice a member has made, the harder revision becomes because revision would devalue the sacrifice.

The third corruption is moral licensing. Because the mission is important, ordinary constraints are suspended. People work

without boundaries, leaders avoid accountability, opponents are dehumanized, or financial exploitation is reframed as devotion. Research on meaningful work contains a useful warning: meaning can improve motivation and wellbeing, but it can also make workers more exploitable when organizations treat commitment as a substitute for decent conditions.

The fourth corruption is emotional monopoly. Healthy projects coexist with the rest of life. Unhealthy projects insist that all non-project energy is waste. Friendship, sleep, family, play, doubt, and alternative identities become obstacles. The person does not merely have enthusiasm; the enthusiasm has the person.

The fifth corruption is manufactured enthusiasm. Institutions often dislike the unpredictability of authentic commitment and therefore reproduce its external signs: slogans, launch rituals, off-sites, applause, internal social networks, compulsory celebrations, carefully staged “grassroots” communities. These can be pleasant. They become toxic when emotional display is interpreted as loyalty.

How can we distinguish generative enthusiasm from capture?

A simple test is whether contact with reality strengthens or threatens the community. In a healthy scientific project, a negative result may be disappointing but informative. In a captured project, negative evidence must be explained away. Healthy enthusiasm is corrigible.

A second test is the right to exit. If leaving a project destroys one’s social world, income, reputation, or sense of moral worth, the apparent enthusiasm of those who remain is difficult to interpret. Voluntary energy requires credible voluntariness.

A third test is whether the project tolerates multiple sources of value. A good organization can employ people who care about the mission and people who simply do excellent work for fair compensation. A good community does not require every

member to experience identical intensity. It makes enthusiasm welcome but not mandatory.

A fourth test is regeneration. Does participation leave people more capable of future commitment, or does it consume them? The World Health Organization defines occupational burnout in terms of chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed, characterized by exhaustion, increased mental distance or cynicism, and reduced professional efficacy. Burnout is not merely “too much enthusiasm,” but extractive environments often spend enthusiasm as if it were inexhaustible.

The final test is plurality. Can a person say, “This matters enormously to me, and it may not matter to you”? Fanaticism demands universalization. Enthusiasm can invite without coercing.

The goal is not to cool every intense commitment until it becomes safe and bloodless. That would eliminate the phenomenon we are trying to protect. The goal is to build correction into intensity: exits, dissent, rest, outside relationships, reality checks, and limits on authority.

The strongest enthusiasm is not the state that never doubts. It is the state that can survive doubt without turning doubt into treason.

PART III

THE SYSTEMS AROUND US

Institutions cannot command enthusiasm, but they can make it either rational or foolish to offer.

CHAPTER 9

The Reliability Bargain

Bureaucracy is easy to mock because its failures are visible and its successes disappear into normality.

A form that prevents arbitrary treatment is boring. A procurement rule that reduces corruption is boring. A safety review that stops a preventable accident produces no heroic story because the accident never happens. Modern societies rely on countless such mechanisms. The argument against deadening institutions must therefore begin with gratitude for what institutionalization solved.

The trade is reliability for discretion. Rules reduce the amount that depends on the character, inspiration, or whim of a particular person. This is one of civilization's great bargains. The cost is that discretion is also where initiative lives.

When systems grow, they often respond to failure by adding controls. Each control is locally rational. A mistake leads to a checklist. Abuse leads to approval. Financial loss leads to a threshold. Reputational damage leads to a communications review. Security incidents lead to access restrictions. Over time the organization accumulates a geology of past disasters. New participants experience the resulting layers without remembering the events that created them.

Eventually, the person trying something new bears the burden of all previous failures. The safe action is to continue existing processes. Innovation remains rhetorically celebrated but procedurally expensive.

Enthusiasm is particularly sensitive to this asymmetry because its earliest stage is speculative. The prospective value is uncertain while the administrative cost is immediate. If every experiment requires a full account of benefits, risks, milestones,

ownership, legal implications, and scale before it begins, only projects with already-legible value survive. The institution selects against discovery.

The alternative is not deregulation in the abstract. It is architectural separation between irreversible risk and reversible exploration. Many organizations treat small experiments as miniature versions of large deployments. A better design creates sandboxes: bounded environments in which the cost of failure is deliberately capped, permissions are broader, and learning rather than success is the primary output.

This principle can be applied outside technology. A school can give students a small budget and a physical space in which they can build without producing a formal business case. A research institute can reserve funding for questions whose deliverable is a better question. A city can permit temporary uses of underused spaces. A company can expose internal tools or data safely enough that employees can prototype improvements before seeking sponsorship.

The key variable is the distance from idea to consequence. Mature systems often optimize resource utilization so aggressively that they eliminate slack. Every hour is allocated; every room booked; every budget line justified. But slack is where recombination occurs. A fully utilized system has no capacity for surprise.

This creates a deep conflict between efficiency and enthusiasm. Efficiency asks how to obtain a known output with less waste. Enthusiasm often produces unknown outputs through activity that initially looks wasteful. If an institution uses the logic of efficiency to govern exploration, it will systematically misprice the activity.

Metrics create a related problem. Measurement is essential for accountability, but measures become corrosive when they migrate from observation to identity. A researcher begins to optimize citations rather than questions. A teacher optimizes test

results rather than understanding. A creator optimizes engagement rather than work. An employee optimizes visible activity rather than value. Once the metric becomes the game, enthusiasm attaches to the score or disappears.

The solution is not to stop measuring. It is to measure at the correct layer. Measure constraints strongly: safety, budgets, legal obligations, fairness, reliability. Measure outcomes where outcomes are mature enough to be meaningful. But treat early exploration differently. The question at the beginning is not “Did this hit the KPI?” It is “Did we learn enough to justify the next experiment?”

A mature institution should therefore contain immature zones. This sounds paradoxical, but it is the essence of renewal. The organization’s core can be stable while its edges remain experimental. The rules governing a nuclear reactor should be stringent; the rules governing a team sketching a new user interface should not imitate them.

The reliability bargain becomes pathological when every part of society adopts the procedural density required by its most dangerous parts.

Enthusiasm does not need a world without rules. It needs rules that know what they are protecting and where they can safely stop.

CHAPTER 10

Work Without the Passion Tax

The modern workplace has developed a peculiar moral demand: not only should people work well, they should care visibly.

Job advertisements seek passion. Corporate values ask for ownership. Managers want initiative, commitment, energy, resilience, and identification with the mission. These qualities can make work far better. But when they are treated as an entitlement of the employer, they become a passion tax: an unpaid emotional surcharge on the labor contract.

The first principle of a sane theory of enthusiasm at work is therefore negative. Nobody owes an employer enthusiasm.

A person may do excellent work because the compensation is fair, the hours are reasonable, the colleagues are decent, and the task is tolerable. That is not a failure of culture. Dignified instrumental work is one of the achievements of modern labor relations. It allows people to reserve their strongest commitments for children, art, sport, religion, scholarship, community, or private projects.

Organizations damage trust when they pathologize this stance. “Disengagement” can mean many things: poor management, meaningless work, exhaustion, insecurity, lack of autonomy, or simply a bounded relationship to employment. Gallup’s engagement measures are useful organizational indicators, but no survey should become a moral diagnosis of the worker.

The positive question is different: when work genuinely can become a site of enthusiasm, what makes that possible?

Self-Determination Theory gives a strong starting point. Autonomy, competence, and relatedness repeatedly predict

higher-quality motivation across contexts. In practical terms, people are more likely to invest themselves when they have meaningful discretion, can become visibly better at the work, and belong to relationships in which they matter.

To this we can add consequence. Many knowledge workers are separated from the people affected by their work. They manipulate representations of representations: tickets, dashboards, documents, slide decks, forecasts, abstractions. Abstraction is necessary at scale, but organizations should periodically restore contact with consequences. Engineers should see how systems are used. Policy designers should observe implementation. Researchers should meet practitioners. Support functions should understand the problems their procedures create and solve.

A second addition is legible progress. Large projects often produce months in which effort disappears into coordination. Enthusiasm weakens when every achievement depends on a chain of approvals. Smaller ownership units help because they give teams a complete object, not a fragment.

A third is honesty about purpose. Purpose statements become insulting when the underlying business contradicts them or when every task is inflated into moral significance. Not all work saves the world. A company that makes reliable industrial components can say exactly that. Specific usefulness is more credible than borrowed transcendence.

A fourth is protection from extraction. Meaningful work can make people tolerate conditions they would reject elsewhere. Academic researchers accept precarity because the questions matter. Care workers accept emotional overload because patients matter. Startup teams accept extreme hours because the company feels like theirs. Mission-driven organizations must therefore be more vigilant about exploitation, not less.

The fifth is the right rhythm. Enthusiasm arrives in waves. There are periods of obsession and periods of consolidation.

Organizations that normalize constant urgency turn peaks into baselines and then wonder why people become cynical. The World Health Organization's definition of burnout emphasizes chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed. The word chronic matters. Human intensity is sustainable when intensity has an outside.

A workplace that understands enthusiasm would look surprisingly untheatrical. It would pay fairly. It would reduce unnecessary control. It would make contribution visible. It would create small territories of ownership. It would allow people to become excellent. It would protect deep work from performative busyness. It would not require emotional display.

Most importantly, it would understand that enthusiasm is a gift relationship layered on top of a contract. The organization can deserve more of it by being worthy of trust, but it cannot write it into the job description.

CHAPTER 11

Science, Culture, and the Lost Frontier

> *Few human activities depend more obviously on enthusiasm than research. The expected value of a new question is often impossible to calculate because the information needed for the calculation is what the research is supposed to discover.*

Science therefore institutionalizes a strange contradiction. It must be skeptical in method and enthusiastic in origin. A good scientist is required to distrust results while caring enough about the question to spend years producing them.

Modern science has become vastly more capable through specialization, professional standards, peer review, instrumentation, large teams, ethical oversight, and public funding. These are successes. They also create a risk familiar from the reliability bargain: the frontier can become administratively distant from the researcher.

Young scientists learn to navigate grants, publications, metrics, collaborations, ethics systems, data-management rules, career stages, and institutional politics. Again, most layers exist for reasons. Yet the cumulative effect can shift attention from the unknown to the career machinery surrounding the unknown.

This is especially damaging because research enthusiasm often begins with an experience of anomaly: something does not fit. The observation is too small for a grant proposal and too uncertain for a paper. It requires time in which nobody knows whether it matters. Institutions that allocate every hour to deliverables systematically underfund this phase.

The remedy is not romantic “blue-sky science” without accountability. It is portfolio logic. Stable institutions can afford a mixture of exploitation and exploration: most resources support reliable programs; a bounded fraction supports strange questions, replication, tool building, negative results, and exploratory work whose main outcome may be conceptual clarity.

Culture faces a related problem. Digital distribution has lowered the cost of publishing to near zero, which should be an age of extraordinary creative enthusiasm. In many respects it is. More people can write, record, photograph, design, animate, and distribute than ever before. But creators now encounter an attention market that evaluates work almost immediately. The result can be a reversal of artistic causality: instead of making something and finding its audience, one studies the audience and makes what is likely to travel.

This is not new—patrons, publishers, studios, and markets have always shaped culture. What is new is the granularity and speed of feedback. A creator can watch the audience react in real time. Metrics that were once available only to institutions are now visible to individuals. This gives creators agency, but it also invites continuous self-surveillance.

Enthusiasm in culture requires protected rooms for work that does not yet know its market.

The larger civilizational issue is the visibility of frontiers. The nineteenth and twentieth centuries offered powerful, sometimes destructive, public narratives of expansion: electrification, aviation, antibiotics, spaceflight, decolonization, mass education, computing. Today enormous frontiers remain—biology, energy, climate adaptation, materials, ocean science, mathematics, artificial intelligence, neuroscience, space, institutional design—but they often arrive to ordinary people as specialist news or risk discourse rather than as invitations.

A society can know intellectually that discovery continues while failing to make discovery culturally available.

This matters because frontiers are not only research programs. They are social technologies for converting uncertainty into direction. They say: we do not know this yet; finding out would change something; there is room to contribute.

The most important future frontiers may not involve conquest at all. Restoration can be a frontier. Making a river ecologically alive again can demand science, engineering, coordination, craft, law, and local knowledge. Preserving endangered languages can be a frontier. Building tools for rare diseases can be a frontier. Making cities beautiful and walkable can be a frontier. Understanding consciousness can be a frontier. Creating institutions that cooperate across deep disagreement can be a frontier.

The common property is not grandeur. It is an open edge with consequences.

A civilization that wants enthusiasm must make such edges visible and participatory. It must let people encounter unsolved problems before professional gatekeeping teaches them that the problems belong to someone else.

CHAPTER 12

AI and the Post-Execution World

Artificial intelligence changes the enthusiasm problem because it changes the cost structure of action.

For most of history, imagining something and producing it were tightly coupled by labor. A book required writing. A program required coding. A translation required linguistic skill. A visual concept required drawing, photography, or design. Expertise acted as a gate. Generative systems weaken that gate. They can produce useful first versions across domains in seconds.

The obvious interpretation is liberation. People previously excluded by skill, time, disability, language, or cost can create. Small teams can attempt projects that once required departments. Scientists can automate tedious analysis. Programmers can explore unfamiliar codebases. Writers can test structures. Learners can receive individualized explanations. If enthusiasm was often killed by the distance between idea and execution, AI can shorten that distance dramatically.

But there is a second effect. Execution used to be one of the ways desire proved itself to the person. You discovered whether you cared about a song by practicing it, whether you cared about a problem by living with it, whether you cared about an argument by rewriting it. The labor was not merely a cost; it was an instrument of preference formation.

When execution becomes cheap, we can externalize the work before our preferences have become precise. The model generates ten logos, fifty names, three business strategies, a research plan, a prototype, and a presentation. Abundance arrives before judgment. The user then faces a new scarcity: the capacity to care enough to distinguish among adequate possibilities.

This is the post-execution problem. The question shifts from “Can this be made?” toward “Which of the things that can be made deserves sustained human commitment?”

AI can worsen dream compression by producing the appearance of completion too early. A nascent idea that once would have lived privately for weeks becomes a polished deck in ten minutes. The deck is impressive, but its polish creates false maturity. Stakeholders begin evaluating the artifact before the underlying thought has become dense. The project enters administration prematurely.

It can also weaken competence if it consistently removes the exact difficulties through which a mental model would have formed. A coding assistant that writes boilerplate may preserve the interesting problem. One that solves every unfamiliar error may leave the programmer fast but shallow. A writing assistant that corrects grammar can free attention for argument. One that generates the argument can deprive the author of discovering what they believe.

The design principle is therefore not “less AI.” It is: compress drudgery without automatically compressing discovery.

This requires models and interfaces that understand the difference between substitution and scaffolding. Sometimes substitution is exactly what the user wants. Nobody needs spiritual growth from formatting a bibliography. But when the task is formative, the system can preserve agency: ask the user to choose among hypotheses before proposing one; expose uncertainty; show alternative paths; invite revision; remember the long project; make provenance visible; distinguish the user’s contributions from generated material.

AI can also become an enthusiasm amplifier by reducing the minimum viable group size for ambitious projects. A small laboratory can build better software. A local organization can analyze data. An individual researcher can prototype an instrument. A niche cultural community can translate and

publish. This could make incomplete tribes more capable: groups organized around specific ideals or projects no longer need massive institutions to access every specialized function.

The danger is an explosion of synthetic enthusiasm. Models can generate praise, encouragement, community messages, testimonials, social proof, slogans, and persuasive narratives at negligible cost. They can make every product look beloved and every movement look inhabited. If emotional evidence can be manufactured, human beings will need stronger ways to distinguish real participation from simulated atmosphere.

Authenticity in such a world will not mean “no AI.” It will mean that the locus of commitment is identifiable. Who chose this? Who is responsible? Who will still care next month? Who bears the cost if it fails? Which relationships are real? What has someone actually learned?

The ultimate promise of AI is not that machines become enthusiastic for us. It is that they may remove enough mechanical work for human beings to spend more time choosing, exploring, teaching, caring, and building. Whether that happens depends on what we optimize.

If AI is used primarily to increase output per person, the result may be more artifacts and the same exhaustion. If it is used to increase agency per person, the result could be a genuine expansion of the number of futures ordinary people can attempt.

That is a much more interesting measure of progress.

PART IV

RECONSTRUCTION

The task is not to manufacture excitement. It is to make wholehearted commitment possible without making it compulsory.

CHAPTER 13

The Architecture of Small Dreams

Grand dreams are overrated as starting points.

They make excellent retrospective stories because history compresses uncertainty. A successful company appears to have begun with a vision. A scientific field appears to have advanced toward a clear discovery. A movement appears to have known what it wanted. In reality, many durable commitments begin locally: a problem is irritating, a phenomenon is strange, a room could be better, a tool should exist, a group enjoys meeting, a question refuses to disappear.

The architecture of enthusiasm should therefore favor small dreams with room to become larger.

A small dream has a concrete object and a short causal distance. It can be attempted with available means. Its failure is survivable. It produces information quickly enough that the participants can update. Most importantly, it can acquire a history.

History is underrated. A project becomes meaningful partly because things have happened inside it. There was the first prototype, the disastrous meeting, the unexpected person who joined, the bug that took three days, the joke that became a name, the first user, the argument that changed the design. These events accumulate into narrative capital. People care not only about the abstract goal but about what has already been lived together.

This is why constantly restarting can be as destructive as stagnation. Contemporary productivity culture encourages endless optimization of tools, goals, identities, and systems. But enthusiasm often requires staying with an imperfect object long enough for it to become specific.

A useful personal unit is the season rather than the life plan. What is worth giving three months? A season is long enough for competence and relationships to change, short enough to remain reversible. One can learn enough of a language to encounter its structure, contribute enough to an open-source project to understand the community, write enough of a book to discover whether the book exists, build enough of an instrument to produce a first measurement.

The season also restores permission to stop. Enthusiasm does not need to become identity. A person can care deeply for a bounded period and then leave without declaring the project false.

The second architectural element is public consequence without mass exposure. Share the work with people capable of responding to it: a small audience, collaborator, user, mentor, class, local community. This creates reality without inviting the entire comparison machinery of the internet. The work needs witnesses before it needs a market.

The third element is skill. “Follow your passion” is poor advice because passions are often retrospective. We become attached to domains as our perception becomes more fine-grained. Competence makes the world less generic. The novice hears a song; the musician hears voicing, timing, articulation, tension. The novice sees a program; the engineer sees architecture. Skill increases the number of things worth noticing.

This means enthusiasm can be cultivated indirectly by becoming capable enough to perceive depth. The first weeks of a discipline may be boring because the object has not yet differentiated. Good teaching bridges that interval by giving learners early experiences of consequence while skills accumulate.

The fourth element is companions. World Happiness Report data on social connection should not be imported crudely into a theory of enthusiasm, but the broader point is solid: human

wellbeing and motivation are deeply social. A project with one committed companion has a different probability of survival from a project whose only social environment is an audience of strangers.

The fifth is protected time. Not “time management” in the productivity sense, but a recurring appointment with the same object. Continuity is a structural condition. An hour repeated twice a week can be more generative than an occasional free weekend because the mind does not fully close the context.

The sixth is the refusal of premature monetization. Some projects should become businesses. Some should not. The question should arrive after the object has enough density to answer it. Turning every interest into revenue teaches the self that value requires a market witness.

None of these practices guarantees enthusiasm. That is the point. We are not trying to optimize an emotional KPI. We are creating enough quiet, consequence, skill, sociality, and reversibility that authentic attachment has somewhere to occur.

A society of small dreams would not look less ambitious. It might be the only reliable source of large ambitions that are not merely slogans.

CHAPTER 14

Institutions of Permission

The phrase "permissionless innovation" became popular in technology because software and networks allowed people to build without asking central authorities. The principle is broader than technology and more subtle than simple deregulation.

Many people do not lack ideas. They lack a credible first move.

The first move may require a room, a small amount of money, access to equipment, a dataset, an introduction, time away from routine work, a legal framework, or simply assurance that a failed attempt will not damage a career. Institutions control these thresholds. They can make initiative cheap or expensive long before formal approval appears.

An institution of permission is one that deliberately lowers the cost of a first serious attempt.

In education, this means giving learners real objects earlier. A student should not spend years preparing to become someone who may eventually do science, engineering, history, entrepreneurship, art, or public service. Scaled-down but genuine versions can begin now: collect data, repair something, publish an edition, design an experiment, build a tool, teach a concept, interview people, make a local archive.

Authenticity matters more than magnitude. Students quickly detect simulated tasks whose only consequence is a grade. The same effort can feel radically different when another person will use the result.

In organizations, permission means discretionary territory. Not vague empowerment speeches, but explicit domains in which a person can decide without escalation. Authority should be

attached to risk. If the downside is small and reversible, the approval chain should also be small. This is a technical design principle, not a cultural slogan.

In research, permission means funding mechanisms that acknowledge uncertainty honestly. Asking exploratory work to predict its outputs in detail rewards applicants who are best at fiction. Small fast grants, shared infrastructure, replication funds, tool-building budgets, and time for uncommitted inquiry can diversify the portfolio without abandoning accountability.

In cities and communities, permission can be physical. Many places contain underused rooms, lots, workshops, libraries, schools, and public spaces whose access rules are optimized for preventing misuse rather than enabling use. The question “What is the worst plausible failure?” should be balanced by “What forms of local life are made impossible by the current threshold?”

Institutions of permission also require reputational safety. Modern professional life leaves durable traces. A failed public experiment can remain searchable forever. This encourages conservative self-presentation. Organizations can counteract this by distinguishing exploratory failure from negligent failure and by making that distinction credible in evaluation.

Another feature is pluralism of goals. If every initiative must align with one central mission, permission remains conditional on ideological or strategic conformity. Mature systems should reserve some space for adjacent questions, minority tastes, and local priorities. Diversity of projects is a hedge against central blindness.

The difficult part is avoiding capture. Open discretionary spaces can be monopolized by charismatic insiders, noisy participants, or people already rich in time and confidence. Access must therefore be designed, not merely declared. Transparent small grants, rotating stewardship, simple onboarding, public inventories of resources, and lightweight

conflict procedures can keep permission from becoming privilege.

There is also a cultural dimension. People need examples of unfinished initiative. Institutions often showcase only winners: the successful startup, published paper, prize-winning project, transformed neighborhood. This creates hindsight distortion. A culture of permission should display attempts in the middle, including thoughtful failures, so that beginning does not feel like claiming inevitable success.

The central distinction is between permission and encouragement. Encouragement says, “You should do something.” Permission says, “Here is a door that is actually unlocked.”

Enthusiasm is much more responsive to doors than slogans.

CHAPTER 15

A Civilization Worth Wanting

Modern societies are excellent at describing futures to avoid.

Climate catastrophe, war, pandemics, financial collapse, authoritarianism, unemployment, unsafe artificial intelligence, ecological loss, demographic instability, misinformation, cyberattack: these are real risks and deserve serious institutions. Risk governance is one of civilization's core duties.

But a society cannot live indefinitely inside a negative image of the future. Avoiding disaster tells us why not to lose the world; it does not tell us what the world is for.

This may be the deepest enthusiasm problem. We possess increasingly sophisticated threat models and comparatively weak public languages of desirable possibility. Utopian thinking has been discredited by the crimes committed in its name, and for good reason. Grand unified visions easily become coercive. Yet abandoning all positive visions leaves the future to consumer preference, institutional inertia, and whatever technologies happen to scale.

The alternative is not one utopia. It is plural desirable futures: many projects that can coexist, criticize one another, and recruit voluntarily.

A civilization worth wanting might contain communities built around restoration, science, craft, care, exploration, education, art, sport, spiritual practice, entrepreneurship, local beauty, open knowledge, and forms we have not invented. The crucial property is not agreement on the highest good. It is the existence of credible pathways from ordinary life into meaningful participation.

This returns us to incomplete tribes. Human beings may need thicker communities than large anonymous systems provide, but those communities need not become total identities. A healthy civilization can be imagined as overlapping memberships in partial worlds. One person belongs to a laboratory, a family, a choir, a neighborhood project, an online technical community, and a philosophical circle. No single membership owns the whole person.

Such a structure creates resilience. If one project fails, life retains other sources of meaning. If one community becomes dogmatic, alternative relationships provide perspective. Enthusiasm can be intense without becoming existential monopoly.

Artificial intelligence could make these small worlds unusually capable. A group of ten people may soon have access to translation, software development, design, analysis, tutoring, simulation, and administrative support that once required an institution of hundreds. This is not guaranteed—power may instead centralize around infrastructure owners—but the technical possibility is significant. If capability decentralizes, one of the most important social questions will be what small groups choose to become capable for.

A positive civilizational agenda should therefore focus less on manufacturing consensus about one destination and more on increasing the density of good invitations.

A good invitation has several properties. It points to something real. It admits uncertainty. It offers a role that is more than symbolic. It does not demand total identity. It allows exit. It makes learning visible. It connects local effort to a larger consequence without pretending that every act is world-historical.

This is a different theory of power from domination. The powerful institution in such a civilization is not only the one that

can compel behavior. It is the one that can make worthwhile action possible for people who were previously spectators.

This also gives a more rigorous meaning to the idea that enthusiasm is a resource. It is not a stock that leaders possess and distribute. It is an emergent property of relationships among agency, capability, meaning, social recognition, and credible possibility. It cannot be stored in a warehouse. It can, however, be systematically destroyed by humiliation, extraction, arbitrariness, overcontrol, and futility. And it can be made more likely by trustworthy structures.

The great project of a successful civilization may therefore be psychological as much as material. After learning to protect people from many forms of necessity, it must learn how to help free people encounter commitments that are not disguised necessities.

This requires a cultural change in what counts as seriousness. Prevention is serious. Compliance is serious. Finance is serious. Risk is serious. But aspiration must become serious too—not in the form of grand promises, but as disciplined experimentation with better ways to live.

A society that cannot imagine anything desirable eventually experiences safety itself as emptiness. A society that can imagine only one desirable future becomes dangerous. The mature alternative is plurality with depth: many strong commitments, none entitled to own the whole human being.

That is a civilization in which enthusiasm could return without requiring us to become naïve about power.

The Right to Want the Future

> *The easiest way to protect oneself from disappointment is to stop lending emotional credit to the future.*

This strategy can look like sophistication. One learns to qualify every hope, pre-empt every objection, and keep enough distance that failure cannot make one ridiculous. The strategy works. It reduces embarrassment. It also reduces the number of things that can recruit the full person.

Enthusiasm is risky because it spends before certainty. It grants time, attention, identity, and effort to something whose value is not yet secured. That is why it cannot be replaced by optimization. An optimizer chooses among values that are already represented. Enthusiasm helps create the values by living with possibilities long enough for them to become real.

The modern world has good reasons to distrust enthusiasm. We have seen mass movements turn ecstasy into obedience, companies turn mission into extraction, markets turn excitement into bubbles, and technologies turn sociality into engagement metrics. We should not forget these lessons. The answer is not more emotional intensity.

The answer is corrigible intensity: commitments strong enough to move us and open enough to be revised.

This book has argued that the contemporary difficulty is partly structural. Successful societies reduce necessity, expand choice, professionalize domains, lengthen causal chains, quantify

performance, and surround action with legitimate controls. Digital systems multiply stimulation. Artificial intelligence begins to multiply execution. Each achievement can make life better. Together, they can produce a world in which people are surrounded by possibilities but have fewer protected paths for turning a possibility into devotion.

The practical response is not a motivational campaign. It is architecture.

Create near frontiers. Preserve small discretionary spaces. Let people encounter real consequences. Protect projects from premature evaluation. Build communities around objects rather than total identities. Keep exits open. Pay people fairly instead of demanding passion as compensation. Distinguish reversible experiments from irreversible risks. Use AI to compress drudgery more readily than discovery. Make unanswered questions visible. Give young people genuine work before asking them to choose lifelong careers. Allow adults to begin again without converting every beginning into a brand.

Above all, restore the legitimacy of wanting.

A strange feature of mature societies is that desire is often permitted only after it has passed through the language of feasibility. We ask for the plan before allowing the dream to become articulate. But a plan is what desire becomes after encountering reality; it cannot always be the condition for desire's existence.

There must be an interval in which a person is allowed to say: I do not know whether this will work. I do not know whether it will scale. I do not know whether it will become a career, institution, movement, product, or footnote. I know only that the question has become alive enough that I want to find out.

Civilization does not need everyone to live in that interval permanently. It needs enough people to enter it often enough that the future remains more than maintenance.

The rare resource is not energy in the physical sense. Humanity has learned to command enormous amounts of that. It is not information; we are drowning in it. It may not even be intelligence; machines are making certain forms of intelligence abundant.

The scarce resource is a reason to spend ourselves.

Enthusiasm is one name for the moment we find one.

A Compact Model

The book can be reduced to six distinctions. They are not a formula for manufacturing enthusiasm; they are diagnostic tools for asking why voluntary energy appears in one environment and not another.

Distinction	What it reveals
Stimulation / Enthusiasm	Stimulation perturbs attention. Enthusiasm gives attention a direction in which it can accumulate.
Freedom from / Freedom for	Removing constraints creates possibility, but possibility becomes meaningful only when people can form voluntary commitments.
Efficiency / Exploration	Efficiency reduces waste around known outputs. Exploration spends resources to discover which outputs are worth wanting.
Permission / Encouragement	Encouragement asks people to initiate. Permission lowers the real cost of a first attempt.
AI substitution / AI scaffolding	Substitution removes the task. Scaffolding removes drudgery while preserving the difficulty through which judgment and competence form.
Intensity / Capture	Healthy enthusiasm can tolerate doubt, exit, plurality, and rest. Captured enthusiasm treats them as betrayal.

Notes and Sources

The manuscript is an essay in synthesis rather than a systematic review. The sources below anchor the empirical claims and conceptual distinctions most important to the argument. Several classical works are included because the book draws on their concepts rather than on a claim that their historical descriptions settle contemporary questions.

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